

Sturgill Fizkratya (commonly shortened to Fiz) wasn't always the person he is now. Originally named Fizkratya Dynami (fizz-KRAH-tia dee-NAH-mee), he was born in the wilds, somewhere near the western border of Nex. As a gnoll, he was raised in pack life, immersing himself in the culture. Originally, the pack had lived in the Mwangi Expanse. A couple of years before Fiz was born, the pack had a split—it had been growing, and some of the younger gnolls decided to try to strike out on their own. Fiz's parents were among the roughly 60 individuals who left. They spent some time on the outskirts of the forests of the Mwangi Expanse, but most of the time, they would travel through Nex or Alkenstar. The new pack would typically stay in one place for a few months, trying to start their own settlements, but they found it difficult to settle down—their presence often drew ire from locals, who would grow aggressive. The pack leadership was as shifting as their location. The pack rotated Chief Elders and its council frequently. The issue with having a population on the younger side—there are no real elders to fill a council of elders. Positions were often filled by those who were strongest, so every few months, someone would decide to challenge for a position. In order to try to establish themselves after each relocation, they would often raid nearby resources, including villages—which did not help their poor reputation. This led to a more violent and harsh pack-life than how the pack was before the split. However, this was the only clan life Fiz had grown up with.

Outside of the more violent nature of his pack, they had tried to stay close to the traditional Kholo society. Ancestor worship, consumption of any dead, ruthless efficiency, love of hyenas—these were all core descriptors of clan life. Hyena familiars in particular were common amongst the pack members, particularly for those who'd lost a family member—it was often seen as a connection to the spirit of those who were lost. After losing his father to a raid, Fiz underwent a ceremony to obtain a hyena familiar. Upon reaching adulthood—about 15 years old—Fiz realized he felt like he didn't quite belong with the pack. After one particularly violent assault on their encampment by displeased locals, Fiz decided to leave the pack and explore the world for himself, trying to expand his horizons and understand why his people were treated with so much hostility. Gnoll life was all he knew—what was it about gnolls that angered so many others? With this curiosity in his heart, he departed from his pack.

In his wandering, he ended up in the desolate Mana Wastes. One day, as he stumbled around, lost, he encountered a mutated giant of some kind, seemingly injured from some kind of battle. Despite its injuries, in his weakened state from his time in the Wastes, Fiz could not escape the giant. It trapped him in a natural rock outcropping and was about to crush him when, all of a sudden, three loud *BANGS* went off. The already injured mutant

stumbled backwards, a trio of new holes dripping blood from its forehead, and crashed to the ground behind it. Leaping from out of cover, a young dwarven woman came running over to him. She reached out a hand to the weak gnoll and helped him up.

“Come with me. It’s not safe out here, and there’s no guarantee that thing is actually dead.” In a stupor, Fiz accepted her aid. As they maneuvered their way out of the outcropping, in the distance, just on the edge of his vision, Fiz could see the heat-blurred outline of what seemed to be a city. As the two of them slowly made their way towards it over the next couple of hours, the dwarf introduced herself as Sturgill Diesa (STIR-gill DEE-suh), of the clan Sturgill. She lived in the city of Alkenstar, which is where they were heading. She offered to help him get back on his feet, and Fiz—although he was weak with hunger in exhaustion—asked why.

“Because it’s a good thing to do. I live by a motto: ‘Do good, until the end of the line.’ Doesn’t matter if it’s a small thing or a big thing; if I can do good, I believe I *should* do good. Ain’t nothin’ gonna stop me, short of death itself.” This was the first time Fiz would hear this phrase, but it would not be the last.

After arriving in the city, Diesa took him to an inn and bought him dinner and a night’s stay. The following day, Fiz spent several hours asking around until he eventually learned where Diesa either lived or worked—he wasn’t sure. Tracking her down, he came upon the Sturgill Gunsmithery. Upon entering, he found a group of dwarves, hard at work, producing more of the strange devices Diesa had used to save his life the day before. The woman in question was working behind the counter, and, upon seeing the gnoll again, she came over to see him.

“Well, you’re looking a bit better! What can we do for ya?” she said, with a smile that seemed too genuine to be real. Having known almost exclusively hostility from non-gnolls, Fiz decided to take the direct approach, so as to lessen the odds she’d get angry.

“I want to do a job for you, as repayment for your help yesterday.” Diesa’s brow wrinkled at this.

“Didn’t I tell ya? I was just doin’ good—” The gnoll cut in here.

“As one does, so another. You did good—you helped me. Now I want to help you—to do my own good too... if that makes sense.” Despite speaking the same language, Fiz wondered for a brief moment if he had misunderstood something. The moment passed as Diesa’s face broke into a smile once again.

“Well, if that’s the case, you can help me wrap up my work here. Maybe we’ll finish up fast enough that I can give ya a tour of our section of the city, eh?” With that, she led him over to the side of the room to some worn down tools and showed him how to clean, sharpen, and repair them. Fiz’s inquisitive nature helped him quickly pick up these skills, and within a few hours, they were all looking as good as new. The two of them spent the remainder of the afternoon walking around town, with Diesa showing Fiz some of the important places in town. After realizing he had no money, and that he had been a fast learner, she decided to offer him a job—it wouldn’t pay too much at first, but it would help him be able to afford food and bed. Fiz, still wary about the situation he’d found himself in here, reluctantly agreed, and thus began their journey together.

Over time, it became clear to Diesa (and the other Sturgill’s he’d worked with) that Fiz was... odd. He clearly wasn’t well adapted to “civilized” life, having grown up amongst other gnolls. Diesa took it upon herself to also help Fiz adapt to city life and move past some of the “wild” tendencies he’d grown up with. Fiz, having always felt a bit different from the other gnolls and recognizing he was now in a place very different from gnoll society, took these lessons to heart. The two spent a lot of time together, both at work and outside it. In the Gunsmithery, Fiz progressed beyond merely cleaning and repairing tools—after a few years, he was even creating guns by himself. The Sturgill clan had grown fond of the gnoll, and his size and build had proven very helpful over the years. Outside of work, Fiz and Diesa often spent time together—teaching each other about their own culture and history, swapping stories from their past, joking around, or discussing hopes and dreams for the future. Diesa would often go out into the Mana Wastes on days she didn’t work, looking for wanderers struggling to make it to Alkenstar. Fiz would often accompany her, learning how to use a gun as well as he could make one.

About 6 years after first stumbling into the city of Alkenstar, Fiz and Diesa were nigh inseparable. One night, the two of them met up, giving each other their own special greeting.

“Do good—” began Diesa.

“As one does—” continued Fiz.

“Until the end of the line,” they finished in unison, accompanied by the sound of their own laughter at the ridiculous nature of their ritual. The pair had spent many afternoons wandering around town or the wastes, helping people out where they could. The motto had become a creed they each lived by now. It had started off as an edict of Angradd, Diesa’s

favorite Dwarven god—something along the lines of “Tolerate no evil, no matter how small.” Diesa thought that sounded a bit depressing though, and decided to flip it—do good, whenever you can, because even the smallest deeds can matter.

The two sat around on the edge of town that night, looking into the Mana Wastes—watching for animals or weary travelers trying to get to the city before the nocturnal predators got them. They talked and joked, as they often did, until the topic of dreams came up again. Fiz didn’t have any long-term goals, at that moment. He was content with what he had. Diesa, though, had one.

“Promise you won’t laugh, okay?” She had a look on her face that told Fiz she was being serious.

“Of course not. I am *very* capable of being serious, see?” He made a face like a child-blowing out his cheeks and crossing his eyes. Diesa broke into a laugh and gave him a shove.

“Ah, shut up. It’s just a dumb idea, but ya know how, outside of Alkenstar, there are lots of places where people do magic daily? I was pretty young when my family moved here to Alkenstar, but I’ve heard all kinds of stories. Makes me wonder—if we could do magic, think how much good we could do! Plus, I have to admit... There’s a part of me that feels like a kid again when I think of doing magic. It’s... exciting. I dunno if I could even do it, I’m not sure how it works, but I’d be interested in trying. They even have schools you could go to learn!” Fiz could tell from the way her words bubbled out of her mouth that she was excited about it.

“Would you want to go to one of those schools?”

“The thought had occurred to me, yeah. There’s one really prestigious one in the Mwangi Expanse, the Maga—uh, Magawe? No, that’s not it... the Magaambya! That was it! It’s really good from what I hear, and I even met one of the teachers one time. He was really nice, and, like, so smart. He came by the shop not too long ago, talked with my parents on one of the days we had off. I ran into him when I was coming home that night and he mentioned they might have an opening, if I knew anyone who’d be interested. My dad mentioned that night that he and my mom had been saving some money, just in case I ever wanted to go to school and learn a different craft. I think it was his not-so-subtle way of telling me I should consider moving out, ya know?” She laughed at this.

“You could do it, you know. Go to Magaambya and learn magic. You’d probably be very good at it, too.” Despite the words of encouragement, Fiz’s voice felt a little flat. Inside, the thought of her leaving made him feel hollow.

“Well, I would, see...” The hesitation in her voice prompted Fiz to ask the obvious question.

“What’s keeping you here? Why not go?”

Diesa blushed—a rare sight, to be sure. Under the moonlight, the dwarf seemed small and unconfident for possibly the first time since the large gnoll had met her.

“Honestly? I think it’s you. I’d worry about you and miss you and... I dunno, this is weird, I’m sorry.” She turned away. Fiz blinked in surprise—while Diesa hadn’t been the most articulate in her response, he knew exactly what she was trying to say—because he felt the same.

“Then perhaps I should go with you. We’ll need to save up some extra money for me, but I think you have a good idea, and as we always say—do good, no? Plus, I would miss you too, best buddy.” He gave her a playful punch—she hated being called that, and he did it just because of that. She turned to look back at Fiz, an unspoken understanding in their eyes as they met.

For the next several months, the two of them saved up money. Fiz eventually decided to propose to her, despite the fact that he had no idea if a romantic relationship would even work between the two of them. To his surprise, Diesa said yes—although she seemed equally confused. Her father, Bodill, upon hearing the news, just rolled his eyes and said “About time, ya daft nugget.” With that, Fiz was brought into clan Sturgill, taking up his new family name. Diesa and Fiz decided to set the wedding ceremony the day before they’d leave town—if they were going to start a new chapter of their lives, might as well go all in.

Two months before leaving for the Magaambya, disaster struck. Fiz was working at the Gunsmithery, while Diesa had the day off. As she had done so many times before, she packed some supplies and went to patrol the Mana Wastes. She came across a traveler with a broken-down cart. As she approached to help, a mutant giant scorpion leapt from the dirt—it had been lying in ambush, using the traveler as bait for a second meal. Diesa managed to get off a few shots, but the scorpion’s poison finished the job, even after it retreated from its injuries.

When news of her death reached Fiz’s ears, he shut down. Diesa, his fiancée, his best friend—gone. The grief tore through him. For the next two months, he continued working, but he stopped saving money. Every night, he would go out into the streets, giving away the money he would have saved—Diesa may be gone, but there was still good to be done. As the time to leave for the school grew near, Fiz realized that he did still want to go to the

Magaambya—for him, and for Diesa. He'd given it up in the wake of her death, but as the grief became more manageable, he realized he'd have to wait to carry out their plans.

In the few days leading up to when the wedding would have been, Sturgill Bodill—Diesa's father—pulled Fiz aside.

“Fiz, you've been like a son to me. You're still a member of this clan, and I know that Diesa would want this, so I'm not giving ya much choice—not that I think you'll complain. I've noticed you've been trying to keep her memory alive—goin' out and helpin' every poor oaf ya see. Bless ya for that. We still have the money we were going to use to send her with, and I know she'd want ya to go. Don't put your life on hold any longer. We talked to that teacher from the academy and made sure that you'd have a shot—we'll put up the rest of the sponsorship. Do it for you, and do it for her. You're a Sturgill, even if ya weren't born one. Make us proud.”

A few days later, sponsorship in hand, Fiz headed off for the Magaambya. With little knowledge and great anticipation, he would go, learn magic, and use it to do good, as one does—until the end of the line.